

Lead Qualification System - MQLs and MSLs

This doc outlines how Marketing identifies and routes leads that merit Sales attention, including scoring mechanics, MQL triggers, and the MSL pathway for event follow-up.

Note: this doc was created with AI assistance, please contact marketing-ops-support for any issues.

Overview

What it does: The Lead Qualification System identifies leads and contacts that warrant immediate Sales Development attention through a combination of intent signals (scoring) and explicit actions (hand raises).

Why it matters: By systematically qualifying leads, we can:

- Ensure high-intent prospects get timely follow-up
- Route the right leads to the right reps at the right time
- Track marketing's contribution to pipeline
- Measure engagement effectiveness across channels

Business context: With 70% of Benchling's revenue coming from customer expansion rather than new logo acquisition, this system must effectively identify both net new prospects and existing customer contacts exploring additional use cases.

Key distinction: Lead scoring is *continuous* (always measuring intent), while MQL is *discrete* (a routing event with cooldowns). A lead can have a high score without being an MQL if they're in a cooldown period or actively being worked.

Qualification Pathways

There are three ways a lead can be qualified for Sales follow-up:

Pathway	Definition	SLA	Use Case
Hand Raise MQL	Explicit request for contact (demo, contact form, event demo request)	1 business hour	Person expects follow-up
Natural MQL	Score-based qualification from engagement + demographics	Standard	Person shows buying signals through behavior
MSL	Event/webinar attendee who didn't MQL	45 days to close	Awareness-building; nurture engagement

Lead Scoring

Lead score measures ongoing engagement and is calculated from two components:

$$\text{Total Score} = \text{Behavior Score} + \text{Demographic Score}$$

Both scores update continuously. Behavior score decays over time to ensure scores reflect current—not stale—engagement.

Behavior Scoring

Behavior scoring is based on campaign engagement and web activity. The core principle: one "good engagement" (booth visit, webinar attendance, content download) ≈ 30 points.

Activity Type	Points	Notes
High Engagement (Events, Summit, Webinars)	30-45	Includes demos at events, high engagement status
Event Attended / Booth Visit	15-30	First and third party events
Webinar Attended	15-20	Third party webinars slightly higher

Industry Signup (Completed)	15	Additive to partial completion
Nurture Highly Engaged	45	2+ click-throughs within nurture
Event/Webinar Registered	5-15	Summit and first-party events higher
Content Download (Gated)	10	
Content Syndication	10	+15 if high engagement with vendor nurture
Paid Media Lead Gen Form	10	Typically combined with other activities
Web Content Engagement	10	
Ungated Content / Webinar On-Demand	5-10	

High Intent Page Visit	5	Once per week (pricing, demos, product pages)
Email Click	1	Once per week

Score Decay: Every 30 days without activity, behavior score decreases by 30 points to ensure scores reflect current engagement.

Demographic Scoring

All leads start at 5 points. Score is adjusted based on firmographic and individual characteristics.

Attribute	Points	Notes
Base Score	+5	All leads start here
Enterprise/Global Account	+1	On top of named account bonus
Named Account (Prospect/Customer)	+1	Has segment assignment

Title Seniority: Director+	+1	
Target Function: IT or R&D	+1	
Active Community Member	+1	
Free Email Address	-1	Gmail, Yahoo, etc.
Not at Target Account	-2	Not named or listed as "Not a Prospect"
Academic	-3	Cannot naturally MQL (can still hand raise)
Embargoed Countries	=0	Cannot MQL via any method

Score Range: 0-10 points

Critical Threshold: Leads with demographic scores below 4 cannot naturally MQL

SQL Triggers

Hand Raise SQL

A Hand Raise is an explicit request for a conversation with Sales. These are the highest quality SQLs with the shortest SLA (1 business hour).

Sources:

- Contact form fills
- Demo requests (including chatbot)
- Inbound email or phone calls
- Event requests for demos

Natural SQL (Score-Driven)

Natural SQLs are identified through the combination of demographic and behavior scores. Higher demographic scores require less behavior to qualify.

Demographic Score	Behavior Score	Explanation
8+	50+	Strong fit. ~1.75 good engagements required
6-7	70+	Above average fit. ~2.5 good engagements required

4-5	90+	Unknown fit. 3+ good engagements required
< 4	—	Cannot naturally MQL (can still hand raise)

Natural MQL Restrictions

Beyond meeting score thresholds, leads must satisfy these conditions:

- **90-day cycle limit:** Can only naturally MQL once every 90 days (score window is 90 days)
- **30-day cooldown:** Cannot naturally MQL within 30 days of any MQL type
- **Not actively worked:** Cannot MQL if connect in last 15 days OR qual call scheduled/in last 30 days
- **Academic exclusion:** Academic leads cannot naturally MQL
- **Embargo exclusion:** Leads from embargoed countries cannot MQL via any method

Important: Even when blocked from MQL, leads can achieve "Hot" Marketing Status. This tracks marketing-driven engagement even when sales routing is restricted.

What Happens When Someone MQLs

| Lead Becomes MQL |

| (Hand Raise, Natural, or Chatbot Override) |

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| Marketo Updates Fields |

| [Current MQL Date], [Last MQL Open Date], [Last MQL Type] |

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| LeanData Routing Triggered |

| Owner assigned, notifications sent |

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| SLA Clock Starts |

| [MQL SLA Datetime] adjusted for owner's business hours |

Closing an MQL

MQLs are considered "closed" when either:

- Lead status changes (to not open), OR
- Email activity is logged against the lead

At close, the timestamp is logged in [Last MQL Closed Date] and [Current MQL Date] is cleared.

Campaign Attribution for MQLs

Campaigns receive MQL credit through the [Last MQL Campaign] field and the [Is MQL] flag on campaign membership. There are three ways a campaign gets credit:

1. Direct Hand Raise

The campaign contains the hand raise action itself (demo request, contact form).

Lead fills demo request form in Campaign A

→ Hand Raise MQL triggered

→ Campaign A gets credit

2. Immediate Score-Driven MQL

The campaign's point contribution pushes the lead over the MQL threshold immediately.

Lead has 85 behavior points + 6 demographic points

→ Attends webinar in Campaign B (+15 points)

→ Score hits 100, crosses 70-point threshold for demo score 6+

→ Natural MQL triggered

→ Campaign B gets credit

3. 30-Day Attribution Window

If a lead becomes an MQL within 30 days of receiving points from a campaign, that campaign receives credit—even if the MQL was triggered by a different action.

Day 1: Lead attends event in Campaign C (+30 points)

Day 15: Lead downloads whitepaper in Campaign D (+10 points)

Day 20: Lead requests demo (Hand Raise MQL)

- Campaign D gets credit (last successful membership before MQL)
- Campaign C also contributed (within 30-day window)

How it's tracked: When a lead becomes an MQL, the system identifies the last campaign membership with a successful status before the MQL timestamp. That campaign's [Is MQL] flag is set to True and [MQL Type] is populated.

MQL Reporting Numbers

When reporting overall MQL volume, use the **unique count of MQLs** from all campaign engagements in the time period—not the sum of MQLs by campaign.

Because a single MQL can credit multiple campaigns (via the 30-day attribution window), summing campaign-level MQL counts will overstate total MQL volume. For example:

Report Type	Count	Why
Total MQLs (unique)	100	Actual number of leads who became MQLs
Sum of MQLs by Campaign	130	Overstated—30 MQLs credited to multiple campaigns

Use unique MQL count for volume reporting. Use campaign-level counts to evaluate individual campaign performance.

Marketing Sourced Leads (MSL)

Purpose

MSLs capture event and webinar attendees who don't qualify as MQLs but warrant SDR awareness. This is not an immediate sales motion—it's for awareness-building and long-term engagement.

The goal: Ensure everyone who attended an event gets appropriate follow-up. These people have "Benchling" in their brain—we want to capture that early interest.

Definition

Leads originating from Marketing efforts (specifically events/webinars) which aren't MQLs but warrant SDR assignment due to engagement.

Criteria

- All time-bound event leads who do not qualify as MQLs
- No engagement threshold—all non-MQL event and webinar attendees are tagged as MSLs

Process

	Event/Webinar Attendee	
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| (Not an MQL) |

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| Marketo Trigger Flow |

| [MSL Date] populated, [Last MSL Open Date] updated |

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| LeanData MSL Branch |

| Routed to appropriate SDR |

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SDR Follow-Up

Message: "Consider onboarding this individual..."

Closing an MSL

MSLs close via one of four methods:

- **Outreach:** SDR logged activity
- **Manual flagging:** SDR or manager closes manually
- **System close:** 45 days of inactivity (automatic)
- **MQL:** Lead becomes an MQL (upgrade)

Measurement

Key metrics to track:

- Number of MSLs created from events/webinars
 - Conversion rates from MSL to MQL
 - Quality assessment: "How many No Potentials?" to measure lead quality
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Understanding the Three Status Fields

Benchling tracks three distinct but related status measures:

Field	What It Measures	Values
Score	Continuous intent measurement	0-150+ (continuously updated)
MQL	Discrete routing event	Hand Raise, Natural (with cooldown)
Marketing Status	Marketing engagement level	Cold (<45), Warm (45-89), Hot (90+), Non-Target

Key Insight: A lead can have a high score (90+) and Hot Marketing Status without being an MQL if they're in cooldown or being actively worked. The score continues to measure intent regardless of routing eligibility.

Technical Details

MQL Fields (Lead/Contact)

Field	Description

Score	Behavior score as outlined above
Demographic Score	Demographic score as outlined above
Current MQL Date	Current MQL date IF not yet contacted. Cleared once reached out to.
Last MQL Open Date	Date of the last MQL
MQL SLA Datetime	[Last MQL Open Date] adjusted for owner's business hours
Last MQL Close Date	Date the last MQL was followed up on
Last MQL Campaign	Name of campaign that led to the MQL (last successful membership before MQL)
MQL SLA Duration	Hours between [MQL SLA Datetime] and [Last MQL Close Date]

Last MQL Type	Type of the last MQL (Hand Raise, Natural, etc.)
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MQL Fields (Campaign Member)

Field	Description
Is MQL	True/false flag. If True, this engagement was the last before the lead became an MQL
MQL Type	If [Is MQL] is True, copies from [Last MQL Type] on the lead

MSL Fields (Lead/Contact)

Field	Description
MSL Date	Date/time record became MSL. Only populated if currently open. Cleared when closed.
Last MSL Open Date	Date/time of most recent MSL event. Retained even after MSL Date is cleared.

Last MSL Closed Date	Date/time when record transitioned out of MSL status. Cleared when record becomes MSL.
Last MSL Close Method	Reason for closure: Outreach, Manual flagging, System close (45 days), MQL
Last MSL Campaign	Name of campaign that triggered MSL status

Appendix: Deprecated Fields

These fields are no longer updated but may contain historical data.

MQL Deprecated Fields (Lead/Contact)

Field	Replaced By	Notes
MQL Type	Last MQL Type	Type of current MQL, was cleared once reached out to
MQL Time Stamp	Last MQL Open Date	Date + Time of last MQL

MQL Time Stamp TIMEVALUE	Last MQL Open Date	Time the last MQL was created
Lifecycle Stage - MQL Date	Last MQL Open Date	Older field no longer updated

MQL Deprecated Fields (Campaign Member)

Field	Notes
Prospect to MQL	Older field no longer updated
Lifecycle MQL Date	Older field no longer updated
MQL to Dead	Older field no longer updated
Vendor to MQL	Older field no longer updated

Deprecated MQL Type: Campaign Override

As of FY26, Campaign Override MQLs are now counted as MSLs. Previously used for leads who didn't hand raise but took action indicating they should talk to Sales (e.g., strong event conversation). This simplified MQL types while ensuring event-driven leads still get follow-up through the MSL pathway.

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